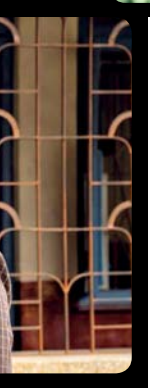
killer, while Vir Das cracked jokes and skulls in the serial killer-comedy *Hasmukh*. This June, *Sector 36*, a film that is based on the Nithari murders, began shooting.

Ayesha Sood, who directed *Indian Predator: The Butcher of Delhi*, says her docu-series would have been unthinkable a few years ago: "Now there is an audience for crime, for documentaries. Because the platforms exist, the craft has also gone up." Serial killers bring inbuilt genre conventions ideal for suspense and storytelling. "The promise of engagement is really high," says Aseem Arrora, who wrote *Cuttputtli*.





"There is a race against time, the question is, will someone be saved or not?"

Then there is the possibility of character study. "I think people have a fascination towards mysterious, weird, taboo and unexplainable things in general," says Akhil Paul, who co-wrote and co-directed *Forensic* (2020), a Malayalam film that tracks two sets of fictional killings in Kerala. In July, Zee5 released a Hindi remake. "The fact that a serial killer tends to enjoy his evil acts... and the fact that they are often smart, and trustworthy individuals, combined with their portrayal as devilish masterminds in the media, all make them perfect candidates for an entertaining story."

For some filmmakers, the crimes are just one aspect. "It's not about how many murders, it's about getting into the psyche of it," says Jindal. He also had the rare opportunity for a six-hour interview with his protagonist inside jail, an experience that was both daunting and exciting. Jindal even found himself wondering whether the convicted killer in front of him was indeed innocent.

For Sood, it was about teasing out thematic concerns around the Delhi killer: class, migration, mental health. "The best stories allow you to open different doors," she says. Despite being a Delhi resident and true-crime aficionado, Sood herself only learnt of 'the butcher of Delhi' and his crimes when she was approached to direct. She believed this stemmed from the fact that the killer, like his victims, was poor and working class, and that rendered the crimes "invisible".

These documentaries drew on deep research, court papers and interviews. But even the makers of *Cuttputtli* and *Forensic* built their stories after studying the phenomenon closely. Aseem Arrora says they hoped to go beyond black-and-white portrayals whilst also avoiding glorifying a killer in *Cuttputtli*. They wanted a "sane discussion" on the subject. "The genre is definitely on the rise, but it needs to mature and have more layers than a chase and thrilling entertainment," he says. "We are trying to push the envelope a bit." ■

- Bhavya Dore

Blood on the Page

Serial killers in recent Indian fiction



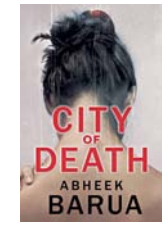
IN PLAIN SIGHT
by Mohamed Thaver
HARPERCOLLINS
₹399; 264 pages

In this debut novel, long-time crime reporter Mohamed Thaver fashions a gripping fictional account inspired by the 2010 Kurla rape-murders that rocked Mumbai.



PATANG
by Bhaskar Chattopadhyay
HACHETTE INDIA
₹350; 256 pages

Bodies keep showing up in this Mumbai-set novel by Bhaskar Chattopadhyay, even after the police nab the alleged culprit.



CITY OF DEATH
by Abheek Barua
JUGGERNAUT
₹399; 288 pages

Abheek Barua's Kolkata-set thriller pits an alcoholic cop against a ruthless killer. She must also battle her own demons and the system along the way.